

Field kit — Echigo-Yuzawa

30-second table · station paths · logistics · 7-night spine · Book this

HUB 3 — Echigo-Yuzawa

This week in 30 seconds

Field	Do this
Sleep	Echigo-Yuzawa Station. West-exit walk: Inamoto / Grand / Kagetsu / HATAGO / Futaba. Or hotel shuttle: NASPA (west) / Sierra (east). Start a no-car week or a station-4WD week . A mid-week 4WD for a farther hill is fine.
Shape	7 nights from the station. You can run the week from this hub without changing hotels. Myoko is a day trip — do not overnight there.
Arrive	NRT or HND → Ueno / Tokyo train → Joetsu Shinkansen → Echigo-Yuzawa
Out	Same station → Tokyo / Ueno → HND ~2 h / NRT ~2–2.5 h plus transfer. Boards on the train. Do not TA-Q-BIN to the airport on Day 6.
Days	Kagura–Naeba / Iwappara / Joetsu Kokusai / Kandatsu. Gala is not the plan — except a brutal dump . Pick tomorrow on japowsearch.com
Soak	Inn tub most nights. Go out once: Ponshukan (inside CoCoLo). Kagura day → Kaido-no-Yu . Iwappara day → Iwa-no-Yu . Hotel baths = ask desk .
Money (per person, group of 4)	Beds + Shinkansen both ways: Path A ~\$1,100–2,400 · Path B ~\$1,300–2,600 (adds split 4WD). Not the week total — lifts, meals, TA-Q-BIN, Kagura taxi, guided BC extra. ¥150 ≈ \$1

Do

- Book the bed first. Start Path A or Path B. If [japowsearch](http://japowsearch.com) shows a powder dump on a farther hill, pick up a 4WD mid-week and raid — you do not need the car all week.
- Book **reserved Shinkansen** seats before you land. Board bag goes in the luggage area on the train.
- During the week, take a **guided Kagura tour**. Book the operator, then go when [japowsearch](http://japowsearch.com) looks good.
- No-car week: screenshot the **Minami-Echigo / Prince** bus PDF the night before Kagura. Name the **east** exit. Sierra bed: book the **east-exit** hotel shuttle **2 days ahead**.
- After the hill: soak, then dinner. Inn tub is fine. **Do not skip Ponshukan** (or Kaido-no-Yu / Iwa-no-Yu if you rode that hill). Do not stack nighter + Moritaki.
- Buy tomorrow's lift ticket the night before when the mountain is chosen.
- If you collect a car (week or raid): **studless (スタッドレス)** on the voucher **and** at pickup. Read the **Parking** column first.

Don't

- Come here for **Gala**. Tokyo day-trippers **and inbound** fill it most days — weekends are worse, not the only busy days. The week is **Kagura**. A **brutal dump** is the inverse call (see below).

- Overnight in **Myoko**. It is a **day trip** from this station (~90–120 min). A second hotel is a different trip.
- Walk up to **NASPA** or **Sierra** — slope / plateau. Use the hotel shuttle (**west / east**).
- Drink and drive. In Japan that is a **serious crime** — 4WD week or a one-day raid.
- Skip a **guided Kagura** day if the week has a clear/cold window. The weather table still picks the morning.
- Count on Gala nighter as a nightly product — **2025–26 was four Saturday evenings only**.

Why this hub — Shinkansen knot, then Kagura

Echigo-Yuzawa is a **rail-and-onsen town**, not an airport village. You leave Tokyo after breakfast and ski by late morning without a domestic flight.

The Joetsu Shinkansen is the spine (~66–80 min). East exit: free shuttles to Gala, Iwappara, Kandatsu. Same side: the paid bus to Kagura and Naeba.

Japan Sea snow can be heavier than inland Hokkaido. The station is not Kagura’s summit. The monthly picture is on the chart.

Mountain	How from Echigo-Yuzawa Station	Why go
Gala Yuzawa	East-exit free shuttle (minutes Confirm on access PDF) or seasonal Gala Yuzawa Station branch train	Not the week’s hill . Brutal dump only.
Kagura / Naeba	Minami-Echigo / Prince express bus from 湯沢駅前 (Prince PDF: east exit). Mitsumata ~18–20 min ¥400 ; Tashiro ~28 min ¥570 ; Naeba Prince ~37 min ¥700 (2025–26)	The anchor — elevation ~1,900 m, gates, Dragondola link
Iwappara	East exit , arcade then crosswalk. Free shuttle ~9–10 min to RC1 / ~15 min RC2	Waki-pow . Lighter inbound than Gala
Joetsu Kokusai	JR Joetsu Line → Joetsu Kokusai Ski-mae ~13–14 min ¥260	Linked domain when Kagura upper holds
Kandatsu	East-exit free shuttle, official ~7 min	Nighter (selected dates, often 18:00–02:00). Confirm on the 2026–27 calendar
Myoko	Car ~90–120 min	Raid, not a spoke . Take it when it is snowing . Several ungroomed runs in the Myoko-area hills. Day trip — you do not overnight there. If japowsearch lights it up, pick up a 4WD for the day. Bed stays here.

Gala is not the plan

Gala is easy: Tokyo in about **71–77 minutes**, ski the same morning. That is why Tokyo and inbound fill it most days.

Do not come here for Gala. This week’s hill is **Kagura**.

The inverse call is a **brutal dump**. Most of Gala is beginners and snow-play, not powder hunters. Then take the free east shuttle. Arrival half-day if you land before ~15:00.

Kagura upper and the Dragondola hold in wind. Warm fronts punish Gala first.

Kagura / Naeba

Kagura / Naeba — why it matters

- **What it is / isn't:** Kagura links **Mitsumata, Tashiro, and Kagura**, then **Naeba** via the Dragondola. Bases are practical, not ski-in luxury. In-bounds gates and true BC are **separated**. Patrol confiscates tickets under lifts.
- **The snow:** Japan Sea volume. Lower slopes can go dense/wet; the high terrain often keeps a drier top on a stable base. Wind holds the upper lifts. Warm fronts punish Gala first.
- **Who it's for:** Mitsumata / Tashiro for intermediates. Upper Kagura and gates for advanced. Off-rope: beacon, shovel, probe, and a **guide** for most inbound riders.
- **When to go:** after a dump, on a **clear/cold** morning — that is the guided Kagura day. Storm morning → lower trees, not alpine DIY.
- **After the run:** most hub riders return to the station town for izakaya and Ponshukan. On the hill, eat **kenchin udon + small donburi** at **Wada Goya** (walk-in, meal from 10:00). Naeba Prince is self-contained if you sleep there — it is **not** this knot.

Ski the ring from Echigo-Yuzawa Station. A guided Kagura day is the one to take when the window is good.

Choose the week: no car, or a station 4WD

Start with buses or a week car. You can add a 4WD later.

Beds are one list. Add a car later if you want. Kagetsu, Inamoto, Futaba, and Grand often sell **1泊2食** (dinner in the rate). That is a meal plan, not a third week type. Room-only is **素泊まり** — HATAGO already sells it; Inamoto has a winter room-only. Ask the inn.

Beds at the station

Why the station, not a slope hotel. The week's night is a walk from this knot.

Powder leaves from the east exit (free shuttles + the Kagura bus). **Onsen** is inside CoCoLo — Ponshukan — then dinner.

Eat and a drink are both exits: hegi in the station, izakaya on the west street, Uotami on the east, **Asfes** craft beer ~10 min west (former nursery).

You ski, soak, eat, have a beer, sleep. You do not need a second town for that. NASPA / Sierra still use this town at night; they are shuttle beds, not a different village.

Same names for Path A and Path B. Read **Why this one**, then the **Parking** column if you might drive.

West-exit walk — book these first. Sorted by walk. Futaba's station pickup is optional; it is not NASPA.

Stay	Why this one	Walk from knot	Parking	Bath / tattoo	Book
Inamoto (越後のお宿いなもと)	Closest onsen walk	West exit ~2 min (Yuzawa 2497)	Yes, free. First-come. No hold. Full → nearby lot (official).	In-house — ask desk	oyadoinamoto.jp · TEL 025-784-2251
Yuzawa Grand Hotel	2 min + easy Path B lot	Official ~2 min (Yuzawa 2494)	Yes, free ~100. No hold (official). Tell them you come by car.	Big bath: tattoos no (official EN Q&A). Private ¥3,300 / 45 min . Day-use for non-guests: not accepted .	yuzawagrandhotel.jp/en · gh-yoyaku@yuzawagrandhotel.jp
HATAGO Isen	Room-only / English desk	West exit , station-front (Yuzawa 2455)	Yes, paid. Guest ¥1,000 / night (from Jul 2025). No hold. Small lot; full = nearby pay lot. access	In-house / private — ask desk	hatago-isen.jp/reservation · TEL 025-784-3361
Shosenkaku Kagetsu (松泉閣 花月)	2-meal. Kakenagashi	West exit ~5 min (Yuzawa 318-5)	Yes, free ~20. No hold (JTB). Confirm on the official page	Kakenagashi. Private bath ¥2,000 + tax / 45 min — ask desk for tattoos	shousenkaku-kagetsu.com · TEL 025-784-2540
Hotel Futaba (双葉)	2-meal + easy Path B lot. Hilltop	West exit ~7 min (Yuzawa 419 ; JTB). Optional station pickup — still a walk	Yes, free ~100. First-come (Rakuten). Confirm on the official page	In-house / private ¥2,000 / 45 min (check-in only) — ask desk	hotel-futaba.com · TEL 025-784-3357

Hotel shuttle — do not walk. Slope / plateau. Not a west-exit stroll.

Stay	Why this one	From knot	Parking	Bath / tattoo	Book
NASPA New Otani	West shuttle. Biggest easy Path B lot	West-exit guest shuttle, official ~3 min . Do not walk the hill.	Yes, free ~2,000 all day (official).	In-house — ask desk	nasma.co.jp · TEL 025-780-6111 · access
Hotel Sierra Resort Yuzawa	East shuttle. Iwappara side	East-exit free shuttle ~10–15 min . Book by phone 2 days ahead .	Summer: dedicated ~30. Winter: Iwappara ski-area lot , not a hotel driveway.	In-house — ask desk	sierraresort.jp/yuzawa · TEL 025-787-3250

Winter rates are date-driven. HATAGO 1泊2食 union band (2 pax/room): **¥19,800–¥41,250** pp/night — that is **with dinner**. Kagetsu regular kaiseki from **¥16,000** + tax pp (2-meal). Enter dates on the official engine. [Confirm for 2026–27](#)

Online compare: enter your dates once and [quote the Echigo-Yuzawa shortlist](#) on one page (Agoda, Booking, and other OTAs). Official hotel links stay in the tables — use them if the rate is close, especially **Inamoto** and other ryokan engines.

No-car week (Path A)

Dinner is in town unless your plan already includes it. East-exit mountain shuttles + Kagura bus. Beds: the tables above.

Station-4WD week (Path B)

A week car **replaces** the Kagura bus and the free shuttles on the days you have it. **Same named beds** — this is not a second hotel ranking. Read the **Parking** column.

Easy week lots: NASPA (~2,000, free) · Grand (~100, free) · Futaba (~100, free). Tight: HATAGO (paid, no hold, small). Sierra winter = Iwappara ski lot.

Wins for: Kagura clock, Iwappara afternoon, Kandatsu late, Joetsu Kokusai without the local train.

Studless (スタッドレス) on the voucher **and** at pickup. If the cell says **no hold**, do not assume a space is waiting. Drink-driving is a crime.

Search intent: **Echigo-Yuzawa Station**. Nippon lot 1-12-4. Not Yuzawa IC. Not Akita Yuzawa.

[Book 4WD at Echigo-Yuzawa Station](#)

Map: [Echigo-Yuzawa drive](#) — pin colour is the time band. Nozawa / Madarao is a day trip; the bed stays at this station.

7-day winter 4WD band (regional analog; Confirm on the dates you enter): compact ¥75,000–¥90,000 / SUV ¥105,000–¥135,000 / minivan ¥125,000–¥155,000. Fuel and parking extra.

How you get here

Full shuttle tables and drive maps stay in the online guide (How you get here). On the hill: Shinkansen to Echigo-Yuzawa, then Path A shuttles or Path B 4WD — Confirm same-day on official pages.

7 nights

Tonight (every night except the last)

- 1. Open [japowsearch.com](#) — Gala / Kagura / Iwappara / Joetsu Kokusai / Kandatsu, and any farther hill you might raid.
- 2. Check **wind on Kagura upper**, new snow, and town rain/thaw — not just “is it snowing.”
- 3. Pick tomorrow with the weather table. No-car: screenshot the bus. 4WD day: studless, parked, no drinks if you drive. If japowsearch lights a farther dump, that is a raid — pick up the car.
- 4. If tomorrow is the **guided Kagura** day, confirm with the operator. Do not DIY alpine whiteout.

If tonight looks like...	Go tomorrow
Heavy snow + high wind	Kagura lower / trees (upper often held)
Brutal dump	Gala — beginners / snow-experience, not powder hunters
Rain / thaw in the town	Naeba upper or wait
Bluebird + cold	Kagura BC (guide)
Gala packed (inbound + Tokyo)	Iwappara (waki-pow)
japowsearch dump on a farther hill	Raid — 4WD day trip. Take Myoko when it is snowing (several ungroomed runs). Nearer ungroomed: Hakkaisan (~1 h). Do not overnight. Bed stays here.

This table **wins**. Take the **guided Kagura** day on the first clear/cold window.

Days 2–6 are **not** a locked tour of Iwappara → Joetsu → Gala.

If the night is quiet: **Iwappara** when Gala is packed. **Joetsu Kokusai** on the local train if Kagura upper is held. Gala is still only the brutal-dump call.

Gala is the **brutal-dump** call, not a “quiet weekday.” Day numbers are not weekdays — do not pin Gala to Day 4.

Soak after the hill is every night. It is not the evening job. Inn tub is fine. **Leave once** for Ponshukan — or Kaido-no-Yu / Iwa-no-Yu if you rode that hill.

Evening = one job. **Do not stack nighter + Moritaki. Do not nighter the night you land or the night before the Shinkansen out.**

Kandatsu nighter is **selected dates**, not Day 5. Gala nighter is four late-season Saturdays — not this week’s product.

Ski Day 6 as a full day — boards stay. Packing is not that night’s job.

Day	Daytime	Evening — one job
1 · Arrive	Shinkansen → station. Half-day Gala only if before ~15:00. Expect inbound even then. Else bags + Ponshukan.	Station-walk dinner. No nighter.
2	Weather table. Quiet: Iwappara . Lunch there: Pittore pizza.	Kamagura , or hegi still serving (Kojimaya / Kikushin). Not Nakanoya (lunch queue).
3	Weather table. Quiet: Joetsu Kokusai if Kagura upper is held.	Moritaki if booked. Not nighter.
4	Weather table. A hill you have not sat. Not empty Gala.	Muran Gozzo if booked , else Yasuyoshi. Not Kamagura again.
5	Weather table. A hill you have not sat.	Kandatsu nighter <i>only if</i> that date is on. Else Uotami or Asfes if open . Not Moritaki.
6	Weather table. Full day — boards stay. The hill the week skipped.	Last dinner (Asfes if open , else leftover izakaya). No nighter (morning train).
7 · Out	Echigo-Yuzawa → Tokyo ~66–80 min (Ueno ~6 min less). Then HND : JR to Shinagawa · Keikyu Airport Line ~15 min (not from Tokyo Station — see inbound table) — about ~2 h to the airport plus transfer . NRT N'EX 53 min from Tokyo, or Skyliner ~36 min from Keisei-Ueno — about ~2–2.5 h plus transfer . Keisei-Ueno ≠ JR Ueno. Boards on the train. Morning hill only if the flight still fits. Not default Gala.	On the train. Allow time after posted airport arrival.

Lights — not the same product.

Hill	When (2025–26; Confirm for 2026–27)	Hours	From station
Gala	Not nightly . Official trial: Sat 14 Mar–4 Apr 2026 (four evenings). Adult nighter ¥3,000	16:30–20:00 (last lift 19:30)	East shuttle or Gala station. PDF
Kandatsu	Selected dates (check that season’s calendar). Homepage has shown 18:00–02:00 on open nighter days	18:00–02:00 (A / C lifts)	East-exit free shuttle ~7 min. kandatsu.com/winter
Iwappara / Kagura / Joetsu	No hub-nighter product for this week	None	Stay in town

Storm / wind-hold without a car: Ponshukan tasting wall + sake bath
· CoCoLo food · station-walk izakaya · skip Myoko.

Book this

You already chose Path A or Path B. Do not re-pick here. Book the beds (links under **Choose the week**). A week car can wait until 90 days. A mid-week raid 4WD can wait until [japowsearch](#) shows snow on a farther hill you want.

August (2026–27 winter inventory): west-walk beds (**Inamoto / Grand / Kagetsu / HATAGO / Futaba**) or shuttle (**NASPA west / Sierra east** — Sierra pickup booked). If gone: Hirokawa / Toei / LiVEMAX. One **Kagura guide** for a movable day. Airport train (**NRT / HND** → Ueno or Tokyo) + reserved **Joetsu Shinkansen** both ways.

90 days out: remaining twins. Path B: Discover Cars at **Echigo-Yuzawa Station**, **studless**, a **Parking** cell that holds a week. Moritaki / Muran Gozzo if those dinners matter.

30 days out: inbound TA-Q-BIN (keep **boots and a shell**). Remaining TableCheck. Save the Minami-Echigo / Prince PDF. Fly NRT/HND after this hub → airport bags **by Day 4**, not Day 6. Boards come home on the train.

14–7 days out: [japowsearch](#) sketch — **snow and wind**, not crowds. Confirm the Kagura window with the guide. Reconfirm Kandatsu / Gala nighter calendar [Confirm for 2026–27](#). **Myoko is a day trip**. Do not overnight there.

This week does not change hotels. The knot is **Echigo-Yuzawa Station**.

Path A's buses already fill the near hills in about **30 minutes** (Naeba ~37 min). Path B is a station 4WD on the days you want the clock — or a 1–2 day raid. Sleep stays here.

Name **west** vs **east** on every shuttle and walk.

The week's hill is **Kagura**. Take the guided day on the first clear/cold window. The weather table wins. Days 2–6 are not a locked tour of Iwappara → Joetsu → Gala.

Gala is packed by Tokyo day-trippers **and inbound** most days. Weekends are worse. They are not the only busy days. Do not come here for Gala.

The inverse call is a **brutal dump**: most of Gala is beginners and snow-experience visitors, not powder hunters. When Gala is packed, **Iwappara around 13:00** is the waki. Japowsearch does not show crowds. Use it for snow and wind, then pick.

A farther hill: **Muikamachi Hakkaisan** (~1 h), Nozawa / Madarao (a day trip — not a second hotel), and **Myoko when it is snowing** — several ungroomed runs. Do not overnight there.

Soak after the hill. Leave the inn once for **Ponshukan**. Evening is one job. Boards go home on the Shinkansen.

Japowsearch is the nightly call. This chapter is the system.

Last season's yen figures are in the tables; replace them when 2026–27 PDFs land.

— JAPOW Chaser / [japowsearch.com](#)

Full guide (bookmark):

<https://japowsearch.com/guide/hsgcvg2cv79dy4pv9djka363/>

Free updates through May 31, 2027. Do not share the full-guide URL publicly.

japowsearch.com · nightly radar at 9pm